“Being submissive means accepting mistreatment or abuse.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching about submission without the matching teaching about how husbands must love. A spouse or leader who used Scripture to demand obedience. Being told that leaving or seeking help would dishonor God. Fear, financial dependence, or isolation. Growing up seeing mistreatment treated as normal.

What Scripture teaches

Christians differ on how they understand roles in marriage, but Scripture is clear that abuse is never God’s will. Paul begins by calling all believers to submit to one another out of reverence for Christ. Husbands are commanded to love their wives as Christ loved the church, to never be harsh with them, and to treat them with honor. God hates violence. Submission in Scripture is never permission for one person to harm another, and seeking safety is not rebellion against God.

> *“Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her”* **(Ephesians 5:25)**.

Also see

> “Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ” **(Ephesians 5:21)**.

> “Husbands, love your wives and do not be harsh with them” **(Colossians 3:19)**.

> “Husbands, in the same way, treat your wives with consideration as a delicate vessel, and with honor as fellow heirs of the gracious gift of life, so that your prayers will not be hindered” **(1 Peter 3:7)**.

> “The LORD tests the righteous and the wicked; His soul hates the lover of violence” **(Psalm 11:5)**.

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” **(Psalm 46:1)**.

Common self-statements

- God wants me to put up with this.
- If I leave or tell anyone, I’m disobeying God.
- It’s my fault for not being submissive enough.
- A good wife (or husband) endures anything.
- Speaking up would dishonor my spouse.
- I have no right to be safe.

Common logical errors

- **Selective reading:** Focusing on submission verses while ignoring commands to love and not be harsh.
- **Self-blame:** Taking responsibility for someone else’s harmful behavior.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must either accept everything or be rebellious.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Staying in danger out of fear of displeasing God.

Challenging questions

- How does Ephesians 5:25 tell husbands to love?
- Does Colossians 3:19 allow harshness?
- What does God think of violence, according to Psalm 11:5?
- Is what I'm experiencing love that reflects Christ, or harm?
- Am I safe? Are my children safe?
- Who is a safe person I can talk to?
- Would God want me or my children to be harmed?

Truth summary

> Submission does not mean accepting mistreatment or abuse. God commands love, honor, and gentleness in marriage, and He hates violence. Seeking safety and help is not rebellion against God. I am made in God's image and worthy of protection, and God cares about my safety and my children's.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage Guidance
- Wives
- Husbands
- Protection
- Refuge/Safety

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage
- Communication
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Being submissive means accepting mistreatment or abuse"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Being submissive means accepting mistreatment or abuse." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How are husbands told to love?
- ☐ Does Scripture allow harshness?
- ☐ What does God think of violence?
- ☐ Is this Christlike love or harm?
- ☐ Am I and my children safe?
- ☐ Who is a safe person I can talk to?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Abuse is never God's will.
- ☐ Submission is not permission to harm.
- ☐ God hates violence.
- ☐ Seeking safety is not rebellion.
- ☐ I am worthy of protection.
- ☐ God cares about my safety and my children's.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Ephesians 5:25**
  "Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her."
- [ ] **Ephesians 5:21**
  "Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ."
- [ ] **Colossians 3:19**
  "Husbands, love your wives and do not be harsh with them."
- [ ] **1 Peter 3:7**
  "Husbands, in the same way, treat your wives with consideration as a delicate vessel, and with honor as fellow heirs of the gracious gift of life, so that your prayers will not be hindered."
- [ ] **Psalm 11:5**
  "The LORD tests the righteous and the wicked; His soul hates the lover of violence."
- [ ] **Psalm 46:1**
  "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Safety journal:** Each day, write how safe I felt and one step I took toward safety or support.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 46:1 becomes: "God is **Sarah's** refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Refuge/Safety" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **If you are in danger, call 911.** In the U.S., the National Domestic Violence Hotline is 1-800-799-7233 (or text START to 88788), any time of day.
- ☐ **Tell one safe person** what is happening in your home.
- ☐ **Meet with a counselor who understands abuse,** not only a couples counselor.
- ☐ **Make a simple safety plan:** important papers, phone numbers, and a place you could go.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Being submissive means accepting mistreatment or abuse": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One step toward safety or support
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Being submissive means accepting mistreatment or abuse.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You are my refuge. Help me reject the lie that submission means accepting mistreatment or abuse. Thank You that You hate violence and care about my safety. Give me courage to seek help, wisdom to stay safe, and people who will stand with me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.